

the forts was equally ineffectual. Farragut, who had never placed much faith in the mortars, soon determined to proceed with his favored plan of forcing a passage upriver. A raid by his gunboats succeeded in opening up a navigable passage through the chain. At around 2 a.m. on April 24, the Union ships steamed upriver to the chain under cover of darkness. They were formed in three divisions, with Farragut commanding the center. Most had passed through the gap in the chain when, at 3:40 a.m., the moon rose, revealing them to the enemy, who unleashed a storm of fire from the forts' guns. As Farragut's ships fired back and the mortar schooners joined in, the night was lit up like a fireworks display. Farragut's boldness paid off, for as he had anticipated, the land batteries fired wildly in their panic and confusion. Only three of the gunboats in the Union rear division failed to pass the forts. One was disabled by gunfire and the other two turned back, rather than attempt to push through the passage as dawn broke. Confederate warships beyond the barrier responded in piecemeal fashion. Their tugs pushed rafts heaped with burning wood toward Union ships, setting fire to Farragut's flagship, which was rescued by the efforts of its crew.

168,675

The population of New Orleans according to the 1850 census. This made the city the sixth largest in the United States and by far the largest in the Confederacy.